

Flock cameras unplugged in Marietta

Ethyn Snider, KTEN News

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MARIETTA, Okla. (KTEN) — What started as a routine vote over public safety in Marietta took an abrupt turn Thursday night when the city's police chief halted a partnership with a surveillance technology company mid-meeting.

The Marietta City Council met to decide the fate of Flock Safety license plate reader cameras following a recent trial run by the police department.

Attendees voiced concerns and city council members raised questions throughout the evening. Resident Jeanette Perez spoke out against the technology, citing the need for "protection against unwarranted surveillance and protection against private citizens."

"We're slowly losing our fundamental rights by agreeing to these search and seizures," Perez told the council.

The final straw came when questions arose surrounding the company's data retention policies. During the meeting, a Flock spokesperson joining via Zoom explained that the camera data is actually retained indefinitely.

That revelation immediately derailed the proposed agreement between the city and the camera company.

"Folks, we're not moving forward any further. Marietta Police Department, Marietta city limits won't have Flock cameras," Police Chief Brett Harris announced to the room.

Chief Harris explained that the department had only agreed to a strict 30-day time limit for the data to be stored.

"They're retaining data indefinitely, and that's exactly what our spectators complained about—that the data doesn't disappear like they say it does," Harris said. "At the end of the day, what we're not going to support is the retention of data beyond what we ultimately agreed upon, which was the 30-day mark."

Following the chief's announcement to pull the plug on the cameras, city council members officially voted the measure down unanimously.

The surprise move brought immediate relief and applause from the crowd.

"I'm really proud of being an American and proud of everyone here that came to speak," Perez said following the vote.

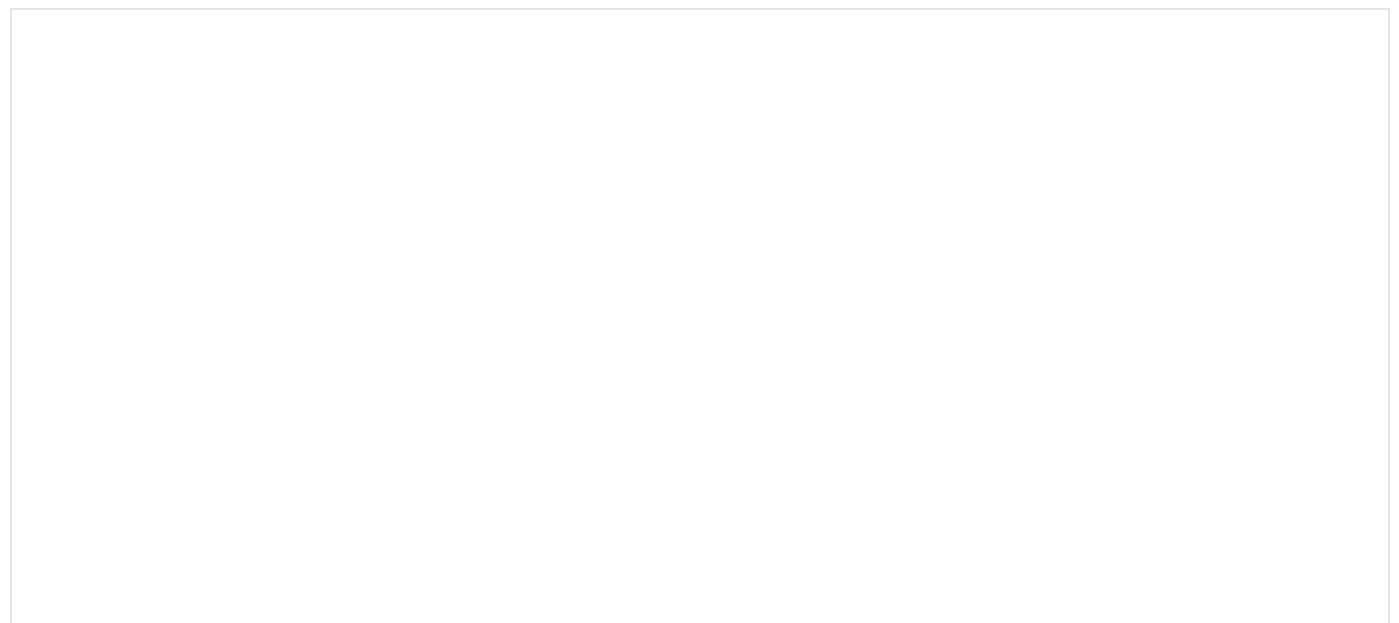
Chief Harris is now shifting his focus to finding alternative options that can balance police investigations with Fourth Amendment rights.

"There are companies that make those type of sensors and have other sensors available, so we'll be doing some research over what kind of technology we can use to our benefit that is supported by the community," Harris said.

For now, however, the chief's message regarding Flock Safety is clear.

"This system is not for Marietta, Oklahoma," Harris said.

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